

Reply Handling

Ten kinds of reply. What each one means and what to do about it.

The general rule: reply to anything human the same day. Interest decays fast, and a reply is the scarcest thing your outreach produces.

1. Positive — they're interested

"Yes, we're looking at that." · "What would it cost?" · "Can you come and see it?"

Do: reply the same day. Don't send a price. Ask for a short call or go straight to proposing a walkthrough.

"Glad to. I'd rather see the space before putting numbers to it — fifteen minutes on site and I can give you a real figure. Would Tuesday morning or Thursday afternoon suit?"

Don't quote over email. You'll have to pad it, and they'll compare your padded number to someone else's padded number.

2. Neutral — they want information

"What's this about?" · "Send me some details."

Do: answer briefly and specifically, then ask one question back. A generic brochure kills this.

"We do recurring commercial cleaning around [area] — nightly and weekly. Before I send anything, what would be most useful to know: frequency, what's included, or rough pricing?"

3. Objection

"Too expensive." · "We're happy with ours." · "Not a fit."

Do: acknowledge, ask one clarifying question, then respond to the actual answer. Don't argue and don't discount.

Most objections at this stage are a request for a reason to feel safe. See **09 Proposal Guide** for the fuller list.

4. Wrong person

"That's not me — try Dana."

Do: thank them, ask for the introduction, update your records.

"Appreciate it. Would you mind pointing me to the right person, or passing this along?"

Worth more than it looks. A named internal referral is a warm route into a building.

5. Not now

"Circle back in the new year."

Do: pin down a month, then leave them alone until it.

"No problem. Roughly when would make sense — after the new year, or nearer spring?"

A "not now" without a date sits in your list forever. Get the date. Then actually wait.

6. They already have a provider

"We've got someone, thanks."

This is not a loss. It's the normal state of a commercial building, and timing is the whole point of this method.

Do: ask one question and go.

***"Good — that's how it should be. When does that arrangement come up for review? I'll check back then rather than bothering you before."**

The renewal date is the single most valuable thing a "no" can give you. Put it in your tracker, set a reminder for sixty days before, and you have a scheduled future conversation.

7. Unsubscribe

"Remove me." · "Stop emailing."

Do: suppress immediately and permanently. No reply. No "sorry to hear that."

One opt-out list, covering email and phone. Never re-add, whatever happens later.

8. Hostile

Rare. Occasionally someone is rude.

Do: suppress. Don't reply. Don't defend yourself. Nothing good follows.

9. Out of office

Do: pause and resume after the date they gave. Don't count it as a reply.

10. Bounce

Hard bounce — the address is dead. Mark it invalid and stop. Repeated hard bounces damage your ability to reach anyone. **Soft bounce** — full mailbox or a temporary problem. Retry once, then stop.

Two numbers to watch

How fast you answer positive replies. Same business day, ideally within a couple of hours. This is the highest-return habit in the whole system and costs nothing.

What proportion of replies are class 6 — "we already have someone." If it's most of them, your outreach is working and your *timing* is off. Chase triggers harder rather than writing new copy.

What not to do

Don't auto-reply to anyone human. Someone who replies to a cold email is rare. An instant automated answer wastes it, and people can tell.

Don't count "we're covered, thanks" as a positive reply. It's polite, and it's a not-now. If you count it as positive, your numbers will look fine while nothing moves.

Don't send a sixth email. If five touches produced nothing, stop. It won't win the contract and it costs you the chance to come back when something changes.